



SAMBA AT THE WORLD CUP, **AGAIN!**

The five-time champion sealed a spot in the **next edition** of the quadrennial mega event.

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Brazil had appointed Carlo Ancelotti at a time when its fate for the FIFA World Cup 2026 looked uncertain. Those fears were put to bed in only his second game in charge. Ancelotti's trusted general Vinicius Junior (**below**) scored the winner against Paraguay to seal a spot in the next World Cup for the five-time champion.

Though the Real Madrid forward had to limp off in the second half, his tap-in from a Matheus Cunha cross on the brink of half-time reassured the chemistry between him and the Italian manager, with the two having won 11 trophies together in the Spanish capital.

On the other hand, it was heartbreak for two-time Copa America champion Chile, which

missed out on a spot in the World Cup for the third consecutive time.

Languishing at the bottom of the CONMEBOL qualification standings, Chile lost 0-2 to Bolivia, through goals by Miguel Terceros and Enzo Monteiro, bringing the curtain down on the major chunk of its Golden Generation that won the first of two consecutive Copa Americas a decade ago.

History for Asia

Uzbekistan, a nation of barely four crore people, scripted history when it qualified for the 2026 World Cup, set to be played in the United States, Mexico and Canada.

Having gained independence only in 1991, Uzbekistan's dedicated focus on youth development had already seen it win the AFC U-23 Asian Cup in 2018 and the U-20 Asian Cup in 2023.

As it drew 0-0 with the United

Arab Emirates in the third round of World Cup qualifiers, it became the first Central Asian country to qualify for the World Cup.

Meanwhile, South Korea beat a 10-man Iraq 2-0 to earn a spot in the World Cup for the seventh consecutive time. Kim Jin-gyu and Oh Hyeon-gyu found the net for the Koreans, which not only triggered celebrations in their country but also in Jordan, which followed Korea into the quadrennial tournament.

Chaos and controversy

England had an international window to forget in June, with manager Thomas Tuchel left in choppy waters after a drab 1-0 win over minnows Andorra, followed by a 1-3 loss to Senegal.

Ismaila Sarr, Habib Diarra and Cheikh Sabaly struck for Senegal as it became the first African side to beat the Three Lions in 22 games.

Meanwhile, Poland's record goalscorer Robert Lewandowski and head coach Michał Probierz had a rift after the latter stripped the striker of his captaincy. Lewandowski boycotted the national team, which then lost 1-2 to Finland in the World Cup qualifiers. The saga ended with Probierz eventually stepping down.



Qualified teams so far:

North America (CONCACAF)
USA, Canada, Mexico

Asia (AFC)
Japan, Iran, South Korea,
Australia, Jordan, Uzbekistan

Oceania (OFC)
New Zealand

South America (CONMEBOL)
Argentina, Brazil, Ecuador

